

THE PRICE OF FISH

written by

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play

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A drama about the cruelty of
the free market and the quiet
death of the commons

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CAST:

SOLOMON - a young man, careful and tired
MOTHER - his mother, old enough to remember a world before scarcity
MRS. TENDO - a fish seller with a hard smile
MR. BAKER - a grocer who speaks as if prices are weather
MAYOR HART - a polished public official who believes markets solve everything
LANDLORD - a man who owns the building and the air above it
CHORUS OF NEIGHBORS - voices of the market, the poor, and the forgotten

1 INT. SOLOMON'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

1

A single lamp burns weakly in a room that has forgotten comfort. A pot sits on the stove. A small table. A cracked window. The city hums outside like a machine that never sleeps.

SOLOMON stands in worn shoes, holding a folded list. His MOTHER sits by the window, thin and upright, as if dignity itself were keeping her alive.

MOTHER

Did you bring the potatoes?

SOLOMON

I will. The market is crowded.

MOTHER

And the fish?

SOLOMON

I will bring that too.

MOTHER

You say that like the words are enough.

SOLOMON

They are all I have.

A beat.

MOTHER

When I was a girl, we did not need to buy the river.

SOLOMON

The river is gone, Mother.

MOTHER

No. It is only no longer ours.

SOLOMON leaves.

2 EXT. THE PUBLIC MARKET - NIGHT

2

The market is bright with cheap bulbs and louder with hunger. Stalls lean into one another like people in a crowd. The air smells of salt, rot, and diesel. Everyone is either bargaining or pretending not to be.

A sign hangs above the fish stall: NO CREDIT. A second sign, smaller and cleaner, reads: PRIVATE LOT. The old commons have been fenced off by a company that now calls itself a steward of prosperity.

SOLOMON moves through the crowd. He passes vegetables, soap, spices, and a row of empty crates where a once-free public square used to be.

MRS. TENDO

You are late.

SOLOMON

I am here.

MRS. TENDO

That is not the same thing.

She lifts a fish from ice. It gleams like a little insult.

SOLOMON

How much?

MRS. TENDO

Eight dollars.

SOLOMON

Eight? Yesterday it was five.

MRS. TENDO

Yesterday was yesterday. The market moves. You should learn that.

SOLOMON

My mother needs something for supper.

MRS. TENDO

Then pay what it costs.

A WOMAN nearby whispers to another.

WOMAN

They say the river is being drained to improve commerce.

ANOTHER WOMAN

They say the price of bread is
rising because the wheat is scarce.

ANOTHER WOMAN

They say everything is scarce
because someone wants it to be.

SOLOMON looks at the fish.

SOLOMON

I only have six.

MRS. TENDO

Then you have six dollars of hunger.

The CHORUS OF NEIGHBORS murmurs. They are tired of being
made into examples.

CHORUS

The soup used to be free.
The water used to be shared.
The fields used to belong to all of
us.
Now the price is written on the
wall.

MRS. TENDO

If you want the fish, take it. If
you want the price, take that too.

SOLOMON, unable to bear the wrongness of it, takes the
fish and leaves.

3 EXT. THE VEGETABLE STALL - CONTINUOUS

3

MR. BAKER is weighing potatoes with a mechanical scale.
The scale is old, but the price is new.

SOLOMON

How much for potatoes?

MR. BAKER

Three dollars a kilo.

SOLOMON

Three? Last week it was one.

MR. BAKER

Last week was a different economy.

SOLOMON

I have two dollars.

MR. BAKER

Then you have the right to be hungry
in a cheaper way.

The crowd laughs, not because it is funny, but because it is helpless.

SOLOMON

What happened to the common garden?
The one behind the school?

MR. BAKER

That place is being developed.

SOLOMON

Developed into what?

MR. BAKER

Profit.

A beat.

SOLOMON

And what do we get?

MR. BAKER

A chance to pay for what used to be given.

SOLOMON leaves with a small bag of potatoes and no peace.

4 INT. SOLOMON'S APARTMENT - LATER

4

The fish is on the table. The potatoes sit beside it.
Mother stirs the pot. The room is colder than before.

MOTHER

You bought it.

SOLOMON

I bought what I could.

MOTHER

And what was left for the rest of the city?

SOLOMON

The rest of the city was left to its own cleverness.

MOTHER

That is a terrible phrase.

SOLOMON

It is a terrible age.

Mother lifts the lid of the pot and sniffs. She closes it again.

MOTHER

It smells like a promise.

SOLOMON

It smells like fish.

A small silence.

MOTHER

There used to be a place where people came with baskets and no money at all. A field behind the church. A row of trees. A spring. We took what we needed and left enough for the next day.

SOLOMON

That place is gone.

MOTHER

No. It was sold.

The sound of distant sirens. A child laughs outside, then stops as if the city has taught it caution.

5 INT. CITY HALL - DAY

5

The chamber is full of polished men and women. Curtains. Flags. A wall clock that runs too loudly. MAYOR HART stands at a podium with a smile that belongs to a person who has never had to count pennies for supper.

MAYOR HART

The free market is not a monster. It is a mechanism. When individuals are allowed to buy and sell without interference, prices become efficient. Supply meets demand. The economy flourishes.

A WOMAN from the back stands.

WOMAN

My son has taken to eating boiled leaves because the fish costs more than rent.

MAYOR HART

That is a matter of personal adaptation.

A murmur.

ANOTHER VOICE

The river was once public. Now it is fenced and guarded. We cannot drink. We cannot fish. We cannot even stand near it without paying.

MAYOR HART

Property rights are the foundation of civilization.

CHORUS OF NEIGHBORS

Civilization is a word people use when they are comfortable.

MAYOR HART

If the commons are overused, they fail. If private ownership governs the resource, stewardship follows.

SOLOMON, now in the back, speaks quietly at first.

SOLOMON

And if the poor cannot afford the price of stewardship?

MAYOR HART turns to him, amused.

MAYOR HART

Then the market has simply revealed the truth of your circumstances.

The room goes still.

SOLOMON

No. It has revealed the truth of yours.

The MAYOR smiles, but there is a crack in it.

MAYOR HART

You are very dramatic for a man who needs a meal.

SOLOMON

I am dramatic because I can still feel what is being sold.

The CHORUS steps forward. They are not a chorus now but a crowd.

CHORUS

We used to share the field.
We used to share the water.
We used to share the work.
Now we share the debt.

MAYOR HART leaves the podium. The city hall doors open to a world where the poor wait in line for scraps and the rich dine in private.

6 EXT. THE RIVERBANK - EVENING

6

The river is no longer a river. It is a long, narrow wound of brown water behind chain-link and iron gates. A sign reads: NO TRESPASSING. A company truck idles nearby. The water is too shallow to hold fish. The reeds are dead.

SOLOMON stands at the fence. Mother is with him, wrapped in a shawl. She leans on her cane.

MOTHER

I remember when this place was full of life.

SOLOMON

It was full of us.

MOTHER

And now?

SOLOMON

Now there is a fee to look at what was once common.

A CHILD on the other side of the fence holds up a bottle of water.

CHILD

It costs five dollars.

MOTHER

Five dollars for water.

SOLOMON

Yes.

MOTHER

And for fish?

SOLOMON

More.

MOTHER looks at the dead water.

MOTHER

The world calls this progress because the numbers are beautiful.

SOLOMON

The numbers are beautiful because they are not hungry.

A beat.

MOTHER

Will you tell me the truth now?

SOLOMON

What truth?

MOTHER

That the market did not simply raise the price of food.

SOLOMON

It raised the price of breath.

He looks at the fence, the water, the empty sky.

7 INT. SOLOMON'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

7

The pot is empty. The fish has been eaten. The potatoes are gone. Mother sits at the table, almost too still. Solomon stands by the window, looking at the glow of the city outside.

MOTHER

Did you save any money?

SOLOMON

No.

MOTHER

Did you save any dignity?

SOLOMON

I am still carrying it.

MOTHER

That is not the same.

He puts a small ring on the table.

SOLOMON

I can sell this.

MOTHER

No.

SOLOMON

It will buy a little more fish.

MOTHER

It bought your father a better life than he had. Let it rest.

SOLOMON

You always say the right thing after it is too late.

MOTHER

That is because the right thing is expensive.

He looks at the ring, then at her.

SOLOMON

I will go again.

MOTHER

Don't.

SOLOMON

I must.

MOTHER

Then go and learn the shape of a world that calls itself free while it charges us for water, bread, and the air that keeps us alive.

SOLOMON leaves.

8 EXT. THE MARKET - DAWN

8

The market opens under a grey sky. People arrive early. The poor arrive earlier. The stalls are already full of produce that has become too expensive to eat and too beautiful to ignore.

SOLOMON approaches MRS. TENDO. She is wrapping the last fish of the morning in paper.

SOLOMON

How much?

MRS. TENDO

Ten dollars.

SOLOMON

Ten?

MRS. TENDO

The river is low. The boats are late. The traders are waiting. That is the price.

SOLOMON

And if I cannot pay?

MRS. TENDO

Then you will learn the price of being unable to pay.

The CHORUS gathers around. They are tired, but they are still speaking.

CHORUS

We were told the market would feed us.

(MORE)

CHORUS (CONT'D)

We were told scarcity was natural.
 We were told that if the poor could
 not afford the food, then the poor
 had failed to adjust.

SOLOMON stares at the fish. He hears his mother's voice in
 the space between one breath and the next.

SOLOMON

My mother said the commons were not
 a fantasy.

MRS. TENDO

Your mother was sentimental.

SOLOMON

No.

He takes the fish.

SOLOMON

She was right.

He pays.

9 INT. SOLOMON'S APARTMENT - LATER**9**

The room is dim. The fish is on the table. Mother is lying
 back in the chair as if she has simply decided to rest
 before the next task. Her hand is cold.

SOLOMON kneels beside her.

SOLOMON

Mother?

No answer.

He touches her wrist. He looks at the fish, the empty pot,
 the small room that has become too small for the life they
 have been asked to keep.

SOLOMON

I bought you dinner.

He places the fish on the table and stares at it as if it
 might become something else if he looks long enough.

The city hums outside. Somewhere, a sign changes.
 Somewhere, a price is raised.

SOLOMON

The old world was not perfect. But
 it was not built on the idea that a
 person could be priced out of bread.

He looks toward the window, toward the darkened river
beyond the houses.

SOLOMON

And if there is no commons left,
then what are we saving ourselves
for?

Blackout.

FADE OUT.

something-funny-fountain